Talking With Dad About How Care Would Be Paid For

Who should be there, what to ask and what to leave open.

Dad has never talked about money with his children, and “how would we pay for care?” is not an easy first question. Nothing has happened to prompt it, so it can be an unhurried one.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: hear how Dad thinks about it, and put what he says and what the family still wonders on one page. It isn't for deciding anything, and nobody needs a statement or a balance in hand to begin.

Who should be there

Dad, first, and it's his call who else. If he is married, the conversation is his spouse's as much as his, since it is their household. Some fathers would rather begin with one son or daughter on the porch than with the whole family at the table. Ask him.

Someone takes notes. If it's only the two of you, that's you, and you read them back to him at the end.

How to open

Start with a question, not a conclusion. Nothing is wrong, and you can say so.

- “Dad, nothing's the matter. I realized I don't know how you'd want things handled if you ever needed some help, and I'd rather hear it from you than guess.”
- “I'm not asking how much you have. I'd like to know what's there in general, and who you'd want us to ask about it.”
- Say what the conversation is for: hearing his wishes and gathering the family's questions. Say what it isn't for: moving money, buying anything, or changing anything he has set up.

Questions to ask

Ask Dad

1. If you ever needed help at home, or more than that, what would matter most to you?

2. What have you already put in place, as far as you remember: a policy, a pension, savings set aside?

3. Is there someone you already talk to about insurance or money that you'd want us to know about?

4. What have you heard about paying for care, or about Medicaid, that has stayed on your mind?

5. Would you be comfortable going through the paperwork together some afternoon?

Ask each other, afterward

1. What did each of us believe before today about how care would be paid for, and where did we hear it?

2. Where does what one of us heard differ from what someone else heard?

3. What don't any of us know yet?

How to write down what was said

Keep three things apart: what Dad says he wants, what he remembers having, and what someone has only heard. Where two people have heard different things, write both and don't settle it. Each one becomes a question for a professional as it stands.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	A WISH, A MEMORY, OR SOMETHING HEARD	STILL TO CHECK OR ASK
“I'd want to stay in this house as long as I can.”	Dad	A wish	
“There's a long-term care policy. I bought it when I was still working.”	Dad	A memory	Look for the policy in the filing cabinet together.
“I heard everything has to be spent before Medicaid helps.”	Karen	Something heard, from a neighbor	Write it down as a question for your Medicaid planner.

What not to decide yet

A family can't settle these by talking. They depend on Dad's own situation and on the rules in your state, and they belong to Dad and the right professionals. Write each one down as a question and leave it open.

- How much of Dad's money would have to be spent, or what “spend-down” would mean for him.
- Whether there are legal ways to protect or reposition anything he owns.
- Which financial strategies make sense for your family.
- Any gift, transfer, purchase or change to a policy or an account.
- Who is right, where two of you have heard different things.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the notes and read them back to Dad, so he can correct them.
- Which paperwork you'll look for together, and on which afternoon.
- Who will take each open question to your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, or a licensed insurance or financial professional.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, decide anything for Dad, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets his wishes and the family's questions onto one page, with the questions left open. Nothing here is legal, financial, tax or insurance advice.

Ready for the next step?

Dad has had his say, and what's still open is on paper. The planning interview asks about your family's situation, so his wishes sit beside everything else you know, and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner or to any conversation about paying for care.

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